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The Photoshop Fix

We dug around a bit to find you 10 awesome plugins for Photoshop—all completely free!

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One of the things we love about Photoshop is the ridiculous number of plugins constantly being developed for it. They take away the inevitable tedium that Photoshop users start experiencing after spending lots of time with it, and, more importantly, extend Photoshop's abilities beyond its out-of-the-box-version—especially useful if you're the type who needs to use weird and fun special effects every now and then. We've generally been sceptical about free plugins, especially considering commercial ones like the legendary Kai's Power Tools and AlienSkin's EyeCandy, but could a bunch of free plugins change our minds? More importantly, how useful will they be? You'll find nearly all these plugins on this issue's DVD, so you can see for yourself as well.

Installing A Plugin

First things first—not all plugins are going to come as installers, so you'll need to know what to do with the contents of some of

those ZIP archives. Photoshop looks for plugins in [Drive]:\Program Files\Adobe\Adobe Photoshop CS2\Plugin-Ins (assuming you're using CS2; the general idea hasn't changed much over time, so you should do fine even with an older version of Photoshop). To keep plugins organised, we suggest you

create a folder here called "My Plugins" or something to that effect. Plugins have extensions like .8bi or .8bf—generally beginning with the number 8, the remaining two letters signifying the type of plugin. Just put the plugin file into the My Plugins directory, start (or restart) Photoshop, and you should see it under the Filters Menu. And now that we have that out of the way...

Deep Paint

Our first plugin isn't so much a plugin as an application that can run standalone, but which integrates very well with Photoshop. A must-have for wannabe painters, Deep Paint lets you take painting far beyond anything you can experience with Photoshop's standard set of brushes, with its Corel Painter-esque natural media brushes. It also features "cloners" that you can use to give photos an oil-painted or sponge-painted look if you choose. You can send an image to Deep Paint from within Photoshop, and fetch it back when you're done with it.

We did experience some unpredictable undo behaviour with Deep Paint, so tread cautiously lest you